



Safer Food Choices for Pregnant Women

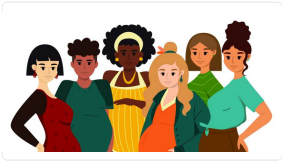
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For Everyone

AT A GLANCE

- Pregnant women are more likely to get sick from certain germs spread through food, like *Listeria*.
- Some foods are more likely to spread harmful germs, including undercooked meat and eggs, unpasteurized milk and cheese, and unwashed produce.
- If you are pregnant, choose safer food options to protect yourself and your baby.
- In addition to avoiding riskier foods, always follow the four steps to prevent food poisoning: clean, separate, cook, and chill.



Why it's important

If you are pregnant, you are more likely than other people to get sick from certain germs.

To prevent food poisoning, some foods are safer choices than others. That's because some foods—such as undercooked meat and eggs, unwashed fruits and vegetables, and unpasteurized milk—are more often associated with foodborne illnesses.

Fact

Pregnant women are 10 times more likely to get a [Listeria](#) infection.



Safer food choices

Use the table below as a guide to making safer food choices. Pregnant women should also always follow [steps to prevent food poisoning](#).

Poultry and Meat	
Riskier Choice	Safer Choice

• Raw or undercooked poultry or meat ◦ Poultry includes chicken and turkey ◦ Meat includes beef, pork, lamb, and veal • Unheated deli meat, cold cuts, hot dogs, and fermented or dry sausages • Refrigerated pâté or meat spreads		• Poultry and meat cooked to a safe internal temperature ⁽²⁾. <i>Use a food thermometer to check.</i> ◦ All poultry, including ground chicken and turkey, cooked to 165°F ◦ Whole cuts of beef, veal, lamb, and pork cooked to 145°F (then allow the meat to rest for 3 minutes before carving or eating) ◦ Ground meats, such as beef and pork, cooked to 160°F • Deli meat, cold cuts, hot dogs, and fermented or dry sausages heated to 165°F or until steaming hot • Pâté or meat spreads in sealed, airtight containers that don't need to be kept refrigerated before opening	
Deli salads			
Riskier Choice		Safer Choice	
• Premade deli salads, such as: ◦ Coleslaw ◦ Potato salad ◦ Tuna salad ◦ Chicken salad ◦ Egg salad		Homemade deli salads	
Vegetables and Fruits			
Riskier Choice		Safer Choice	
• Any raw or undercooked sprouts, such as alfalfa and bean • Unwashed fresh fruits and vegetables, including lettuce and other leafy greens • Cut melon left out for more than 2 hours (1 hour if it's exposed to temperatures hotter than 90°F, such as a picnic or hot car)		• Cooked sprouts (until steaming hot) • Washed vegetables and fruits (washed and then cooked are safest) • Freshly cut melon or cut melon kept refrigerated for 7 or fewer days	
Juice			
Riskier Choice		Safer Choice	
Unpasteurized juice or cider		• Pasteurized juice or cider • Unpasteurized juice or cider brought to a rolling boil for at least 1 minute before drinking	
Milk			
Riskier Choice		Safer Choice	
Unpasteurized (raw) milk and dairy products made from raw milk		Pasteurized milk and dairy products made from pasteurized milk	
Cheese			
Riskier Choice		Safer Choice	

• Soft cheese made from unpasteurized (raw) milk—for example, queso fresco, brie, camembert, and blue-veined cheese • Any queso fresco-type cheese, when made with pasteurized or unpasteurized (raw) milk, such as queso fresco, queso blanco, requesón, or similar fresh, soft cheeses • Unheated cheese sliced at a deli	
• Hard cheese, when made with pasteurized milk, such as Asiago, Cheddar, Parmesan, or Swiss/Gruyere/Emmental • Cottage cheese, cream cheese, string cheese, feta and mozzarella, when made with pasteurized milk • Pasteurized soft cheeses heated to an internal temperature of 165°F or until steaming hot • Deli-sliced cheeses heated to 165°F or until steaming hot	
Eggs	
Riskier Choice	Safer Choice
Raw or undercooked (runny) eggs, and foods that contain raw or undercooked eggs, such as • Caesar salad dressing • Raw cookie dough or raw batter • Homemade eggnog	• Eggs cooked until the yolks and whites are firm • Egg dishes (frittata, quiche, casserole) cooked to an internal temperature of 165°F if they contain meat or poultry • Egg dishes cooked to an internal temperature of 160°F if they do not contain meat or poultry • Pasteurized eggs in foods that will not be cooked to a safe temperature, such as mousse and salad dressing
Seafood	
Riskier Choice	Safer Choice
• Raw or undercooked fish or shellfish, including sashimi, sushi, and ceviche • Refrigerated smoked seafood (except in a cooked dish). Refrigerated smoked seafood is usually labeled as "nova-style," "lox," "kippered," "smoked," or "jerky" • Fish that contain high amounts of mercury, such as ◦ Shark ◦ Swordfish ◦ King mackerel ◦ Tilefish	• Fish cooked to a safe internal temperature of 145°F or until the flesh is opaque and separates easily with a fork • Shellfish cooked until shells open during cooking or until flesh is pearly or white, and opaque • Smoked fish in sealed, airtight packages or containers that don't need to be kept refrigerated before opening • Smoked fish cooked in a casserole or other cooked dishes • Canned fish and seafood • Fish that contain low amounts of mercury, such as ◦ Shrimp ◦ Canned light tuna ◦ Salmon ◦ Pollock ◦ Catfish
Flour	
Riskier Choice	Safer Choice
Raw dough or raw batter made with raw (uncooked) flour	• Food made with flour that is cooked following the package directions or recipe • Dough and batter made with heat-treated flour and pasteurized eggs • Dough and batter that is labeled "edible" or "safe to eat raw"

Resources

[FoodSafety.gov: Pregnant Women](#)

Foodborne Outbreaks

SAFER FOOD CHOICES FOR PREGNANT WOMEN

Using the following information, select the safer food choice for pregnant women.



	FOOD	UNSAFER CHOICE	SAFER CHOICE
1.		hamburger with cheese and tomato slice	hamburger with cheese, tomato slice, and lettuce
2.		slice of pepperoni pizza	slice of pepperoni pizza with extra cheese
3.		salad with lettuce, tomatoes, and cucumbers	salad with lettuce, tomatoes, cucumbers, and dressing
4.		chicken soup with rice	chicken soup with rice and vegetables
5.		whole milk	whole milk with added vitamin D
6.		slice of watermelon	slice of watermelon with rind
7.		fruit salad with apples, oranges, and grapes	fruit salad with apples, oranges, grapes, and kiwi
8.		spaghetti with meat sauce	spaghetti with meat sauce and vegetables
9.		chicken and rice	chicken and rice with vegetables
10.		fruit salad with apples, oranges, and grapes	fruit salad with apples, oranges, grapes, and kiwi

FOOD SAFETY FACTS: Pregnant women should avoid eating raw or undercooked meat, poultry, fish, and eggs. They should also avoid eating soft cheeses, deli meats, and unpasteurized milk. Pregnant women should also avoid eating raw vegetables and fruits that have been in contact with raw meat.

Information on which foods are safer to consume and which are more likely to cause food poisoning fo...

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National Center for Emerging and Zoonotic Infectious Diseases (NCEZID)